

restored in a company so they won't take their business elsewhere. Also remember that these people have to sit and read complaints day in, day out. Another average "I'm pissed off—what are you gonna do about it" letter is hardly going to cut through the clutter.

You must get across that you are a customer who still wants to come back and use that company's products or services, but need a show of good faith in order to do so. Act a little wounded if you must. The outcome will favor you much more.

Threats and rants will get you nowhere

I've worked closely with CSRs over my many years in advertising, and they've all had threats of varying proportions. From legal action to verbal abuse and violence, it's all been done many times. And those reactions fall on deaf ears. You may get lucky and get a result, but usually you'll get an apology letter, if anything at all. More often than not, threats go nowhere because people know you write them in a state of anger and frustration, and 99% of people will never see the threats through. They just want to vent. So, calm down before you write your letter, take a few deep breaths, and put everything in perspective. You'll get much further

from that starting point than with steam shooting out of your ears.

Handy phrases to use in your letters

Try a few of these next time; they're worth their weight in gold. And use this tone of disappointment, not anger, throughout your letter.

- Since I can remember, I've been a loyal customer of . . .
- I have always enjoyed your products/services but was really disappointed when . . .
- I was shocked to see such bad service from a company I've grown to trust . . .
- I feel let down by this incident. It's so unlike your company . . .
- Can you restore my faith in . . .

You get the idea. Let them know they are a good friend who has let you down. Someone you care about, and want to trust again. That's a good story to tell, and a good way to get someone to listen. It's far easier for a company to save an existing customer than spend more marketing dollars acquiring a new one. As long as you indicate that you want to be saved, that is.

Letter checklist

- Include your contact details. They need to know who to reply to.